only after 2013. On some aspects of the development debate, they find themselves on the same side.

Yet, an intractable boundary dispute and different politico-economic models have created a competitive narrative in this very period. That they are immediate neighbours has added to the intricacy of their ties. A common periphery and balance of power have also contributed to a sense of rivalry. It is also a reality that China's reach and influence has extended significantly during this period. A lack of appreciation of this aspect 15 years ago has added to our vulnerability in the Indian Ocean.

From the Indian perspective, the answers are in a combination of realms, many of them centring on building our national strengths and upgrading our infrastructure. But there is also a conceptual transformation underway in the diplomatic approach. The global landscape today offers many more opportunities for India to leverage, once it goes back to the realist tradition.

The serious debate about the future of this relationship today dwells on how to establish the most advantageous modus vivendi. Because it is an immediate neighbour, China's rapid growth has been particularly impactful, both on the balance with India as well as its presence in their common and near periphery. Moreover, for various reasons, China has not given the same regard to India's rise as the rest of the world. In their ties, the present is very much shaped by the past, whether we speak of the ground situation, national power or even sentiment. And the past is not without its share of problems.

At the same time, their cumulative effect on the established world order is creating greater openings for its change. The fact is that neither can wish the other away and both clearly have the ability to run the long race. Even otherwise, they had to take the rest of the world into consideration when it came to calculations about each other. Perhaps, this is more so in the current global scenario. If and how they come to terms seriously will not only shape the prospects of the two countries but that of the continent, and perhaps even the world now.

Most Indians are familiar with the modern history of our bilateral ties. Perhaps not everyone may know every nuance of how it evolved. But generally, people have a sense of the ups and downs of this relationship. The first decade of the 1950s can only be described as one of Indian naiveté. On multiple issues, Indian foreign policy took up China's cause to